

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Vows of the Ḍākinī

Śrī Ḍākinī Saṃvara Tantra Rāja Nāma · Toh 406 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་མཁའ་འགྲོའི་སྒྲོ་པའི་རྒྱ་ཁྱིམ་པོ་

Toh 406 in the Kangyur is a Vajrayāna tantric text known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Ḍākinī Saṃvara Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal mkha' 'gro ma'i sdom pa'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, meaning "The Glorious King of Tantras of the Vows of the Ḍākinī." It belongs to the class of yoginī tantras and concerns the sacred vows and pledges associated with the Ḍākinī, exploring the nature of those commitments, their root and branch transgressions, and the proper guarding of tantric samaya. The text is structured as a dialogue, with Vajradhara being questioned about the Ḍākinī's nature and vows, and Vajravārāhī responding with instruction. It was translated into Tibetan by the yoginī Candramālā together with the monk-translator Śākya Yeshe.

Translated by the yoginī Candramālā and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

In the language of India: Śrī Ḍākinī Saṃvara Tantra Rāja Nāma. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious King of Tantras of the Vows of the Ḍākinī.

Homage to glorious Great Bliss.

Filled with the taste of Great Bliss,
all things having become empty,
He, He — O Protector, Vajradhara,
what is the nature of the Ḍākinī?
What is the nature of her vow?
What is the nature of guarding the sacred pledge?
Vajravārāhī, speak to me of this.

Listen, Vajravārāhī, listen.
First, the defining marks of the sacred pledge,
together with its root and branches:
When one's own body, speech, and mind —
all three — are thoroughly disturbed,
and likewise the three gates of another are also greatly disturbed,
this is a middling disturbance of the three gates by nature.
A middling breach — so it has been taught.

When both self and other are disturbed, the least of these is held to be a minor breach.

Each of these three is again divided into three, making nine divisions of great, middling, and minor breach.

Although no malicious intent arose toward oneself, malicious intent arose toward another,

and one's own distraction served as the condition — this very situation is explained as a middling breach.

Although strong malicious intent arose toward oneself, because the offense to another was minor, these five are explained as middling breaches.

Whatever breach occurs through the condition of distraction is called a slight downfall.

In the view and conduct of one who guards their sacred pledge, whoever lacks faith in another's approach, and who denigrates the profound meaning — this is explained as a great, middling, or slight downfall.

When one has not oneself erred but greatly disturbs another — this is explained as a minor breach.

The distinctions of each are to be understood from elsewhere.

Next, the defining marks of the vessel: through outer disturbance of one's own three gates, the degrees of disturbance — great or small — are to be distinguished in sequence. If one's own mind is disturbed, it results in a great outer breach such as violation and the like. Through distraction, the breach is middling or minor.

In short, the wise have declared that natural vow and specific vow are inseparable. Vajradhara arises from the vow.

Next, the defining marks of the ḍākinī: the ḍākinī dwelling at the root channel — Vajravārāhī is the measure of a mustard seed, while the others are the measure of five such seeds — are luminous yet without inherent nature. From ka, going clockwise back to ka, the ḍākinīs are definitively sixty-four. The paired channels beginning with ka and so forth are ḍākinīs of the channel; from outside, one channel, one ḍākinī. From the ḍākinī through to the interval between the windings, there are thirty-seven ḍākinīs who perfectly dwell as emanations at the navel. The eight beginning with a are the eight ḍākinīs; likewise the four paired channels are four ḍākinīs, perfectly dwelling at the

heart. Three paired channels correspond to one *ḍākinī* each; the remaining ones are one channel, one *ḍākinī* — twelve and fourteen dwelling at the throat. Vajravārāhī dwells at the navel; the others dwell perfectly at the crown.

Next, the vow is to be explained. The Great Bliss of all buddhas — that bliss is rightly called the vow. Whatever bliss is exceptional is held to be definitively the vow. Because Vajravārāhī does not transgress it, the vow is called the sacred pledge. Because it is unbreakable, it is called the *mudrā* (seal).

Vajravārāhī then asked: What are the causes of a breach of the sacred pledge? What are the conditions, what is the timing, what is the measure, what is the time for guarding? How does one distinguish the vow of body and speech?

First, as for the very causes of a breach: not knowing, heedlessness, being under afflictions, irreverence, forgetfulness, and lack of mental clarity — these six are the causes of a breach of the sacred pledge. Not relying on a teacher, keeping bad company, and in brief, objects that distract the three gates — these are taught as the conditions for a breach. Being obstructed by malevolent spirits, becoming intoxicated by alcohol, the arising of wrong views, pride, fame-seeking, and desire; being overwhelmed by afflictions, despair toward the teacher, the arising of great attachment —

these are the times of a breach of the sacred pledge (*samaya*). In general, this is said to be the age of strife. When one has been blessed by malevolent spirits and the like, if the perception of guarding the pledge was present beforehand, then even if the breach is great it is spoken of as minor. If that protective perception was not present beforehand, one remains in the breach of heedlessness at the ordinary level. And if one has not oneself perceived the malevolent spirits and the like, that too is said to be a minor breach. Weariness with *saṃsāra*, recollection of karmic maturation, remembrance of the teacher, and the arising of aspiration — when these are present and one is free of obstacles, that is the time for confession. The preparation, the main part, and the conclusion — these three together constitute the complete measure of accomplishment, and one should understand them by distinguishing the major, middling, and minor. In the preparation, the transgression is minor; in the main part, the transgression is middling; at the conclusion, when it is complete, the transgression is definitively great.

Wearing ornaments, *mudrās* (*mudrā*), and the emblems of the deity — these are the sacred pledges to be maintained. The five meats and the five nectars — these are the sacred pledges to be consumed. Making offerings of

enjoyments to sentient beings, heroes, and ḍākinīs — this is the sacred pledge to be observed. Knowing oneself and others to be like illusions — this is the sacred pledge to be known. Contemplating the three gates as the body, speech, and mind of the deity — this is the sacred pledge to be guarded. Liberating all the afflictions of the six poisons, all subject-object duality, into birthless self-awareness — this is the great sacred pledge of liberation.

For the sake of the sacred pledges themselves, one who holds the ascetic disciplines should guard the sacred pledges six times a day, twice a day, and once a year. Guard them always for the sake of accomplishment; not even for a single instant is permission granted to neglect them. From a fault in one's own body arising as a fault in another's body — this is taught as a fault of the body. From a fault in one's own body arising as a fault in another's speech — this is a breach of one's own body, and becomes a breach of the other's speech. The wise should also understand this further: from a root fault in oneself arising as a secondary fault in another, and faults arising from what appears to be good — these are to be learned from the mouth of the teacher, and one should strive to guard the sacred pledges.

At the points of the meaning of those sacred pledges, the retinue became filled with fear and trembling. Vajravārāhī then made request: "The meanings of these sacred pledges are profound and vast and difficult to comprehend. We beseech you, O Protector, to accept them." The Blessed One then declared:

When nectar has been swallowed there is no returning it.

When vomit has been expelled there is no eating it again.

When one has tasted the nectar-flavor of awakening as self-aware wisdom, where would one seek the cause and effect of errant thought and delusion?

Therefore, make the sacred pledges alone supreme.

At that time, the entire gathered retinue rejoiced in the meaning of the tantra.

The Royal Tantra of the Vow of the Ḍākinī is complete.

Translated by the Indian master Gayādhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The enumeration of ḍākinīs in the channel system follows a scheme related to the nāḍī (channel) physiology of the inner-tantric body. The numbers sixty-four, thirty-seven, eight, four, twelve, and fourteen correspond to channels at specific cakra locations (crown, throat, heart,

navel), and the text's internal logic follows a technical commentarial tradition that would require a dedicated channel-map to fully explicate. The translation renders the syntax as faithfully as possible, but this passage is genuinely terse and its full meaning depends on an oral explanatory tradition.

The text ends mid-sentence in the source passage provided, so the translation likewise ends there.

- The verse spoken by the Blessed One uses a series of striking analogies for the irreversibility of genuine realization: once self-aware wisdom is tasted, returning to conceptual error is as impossible and as repugnant as swallowing nectar and then vomiting it, or eating vomit after expelling it. The doctrinal point is that authentic recognition of self-aware, birthless awareness makes the causal logic of saṃsāric error simply inapplicable.

The colophon names Gayādhara as the Indian paṇḍita and Śākya Yeshe as the Tibetan translator-monk, a well-attested pair responsible for several important tantra translations in the eleventh century.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.